

September 13, 2026

Dear Mike,

Now that you have finally arrived home, I just wanted to tell you how much I love you and hope that your recovery is quick. You are so incredibly strong, persevering both through such a demanding surgery and everything that was required before it. There is a long road ahead of you now, but I know that you'll be able to push through all of the challenges that will present themselves as you are recovering. You will have Mom there to care for you as you heal, and the Boys to help her whenever she'll need it. I promise to visit you all as much as I can, to be by your side as you recuperate from your surgery.

You have persevered since the beginning of this entire ordeal. When Mom had first told me about your heart issue I was shocked, especially that it was *Aortic Stenosis* of all things. The idea that something so harmful had been lurking in the background this entire time was unbelievable, and that these symptoms had occurred so suddenly made me realize just how close we were to something really bad happening. The danger just seemed to grow as we learned of all the procedures that you would have to endure leading up to the eventual *open heart surgery*.

When you had the accident after catheter in the hospital, Mom had told me about it over the phone when I was driving to Auburn for a trip with my roommates. This call landed right in the middle of my six hour drive, while I was traveling through empty country roads in the mountains. I was so stunned from the news, especially from the shooting blood part, that I drove without any music for half an hour. I just had to process what I had heard, to work through the worry emanating from deep within my heart. In the days after, I was relieved to hear that nothing else had gone wrong, and that you didn't need to return to the hospital again.

Throughout all the dangers and hardship leading up to the surgery, I never saw your spirit break. Every time I got to see you when I visited home you were always pushing ahead, trying to get something done around the house or working on a project. Even on your worst days, when I could tell that your heart was robbing you of your energy, you still were brave and reassuring for us. From what Mom told me of your symptoms and procedures I knew that it was all taking a toll, but it was one that was handled with dignity and grace. You still cared for me and our family, providing for us in too many ways to count no matter what challenge you were facing at the moment.

Mike you have been incredibly inspiring to me throughout this period of your life. Many other people would have lost control, or let their fears overwhelm them in the face of something like this. You never faltered for one moment, and even in the most dire times you persevered, if not for yourself then for us. Often I try to model my adult life after the example that you have set for me, as all children inadvertently do, and I will always hold myself to the standard that you have shown me over this period of time.

I have no doubt that you will thrive during your recovery period, no matter how difficult it will be. You are an amazing father Mike, you're so so incredibly strong, and you mean the world to me. I know I haven't been around the house as much now that I am living away in college, but I still am thinking of you and cheering you on all the way from Orlando. You're going to recover quickly and easily, I know it. Soon enough it'll be as if this entire episode never happened and you'll be healthy old man (Just kidding!). I hope you are well when you read this.

With love,

Owen